

Alessandro Volta

The man who gave the world its first **BATTERY** and unlocked the secrets of electricity

By the way...

my name is on every battery. The amount of electrical potential a battery has is measured in "volts" (named after me).

All about me

- **BORN:** 1745
- **DIED:** 1827
- **NATIONALITY:** Italian
- **FACTOID:** I discovered methane gas.
- **IN A NUTSHELL:** I was born in Como, Italy. I was a professor of experimental physics and I spent most of my life studying electricity.

Getting a leg up

In 1786, an Italian anatomist, Luigi Galvani, discovered he could make a frog's leg twitch when he **pressed steel rods against it**. Volta realized that the wet leg caused an **ELECTRIC CURRENT** to run between the steel rods and the tin plate beneath the frog. The key to this was the **two different metals**.



When Volta demonstrated his device to Napoleon, he made Volta a count.

The voltaic pile was the forerunner of modern batteries.

Volta's battery

Volta tried to recreate the effect in his own way. In 1800, he used **disks of copper and zinc** for the different metals and, to replace the frog's leg, he used cardboard soaked in salt water. When he stacked them up in layers, **electricity flowed through the pile**. Volta called the device a "voltaic pile." He had just **INVENTED THE BATTERY**.

